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Confronting Inauthentic Living in The Zoo Story

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Abstract

This is a paper on one of the most revered plays of Edward Albee, *The Zoo Story*. The play has been important for many years now precisely because Albee questions the most consistent act of everyday life in any culture up to the present moment: of unquestionably adopting metanarratives or ideological-fictional patterns to define our roles and lives, regardless of them being in dissonance with our personal desires or preferences. However, this betrayal against one's self is not without reason. The advent of the second half of the twentieth century brings with itself a new factor: the postmodern condition. The fragmentation of all metanarratives took away the sense of total assurance with which people functioned in life and they were confronted with the postmodern condition of not having any unquestionable grounds of meaning and knowledge. This led to the disturbing feeling of perpetual existential uncertainty in everyday life since not a lot could be known for sure anymore.

The paper explores how Peter, the main character of the play, forcefully forgets about the postmodern uncertainty to live his everyday life on the basis of the metanarrative of the American Dream, so he could live his life with ease of feeling complete certainty about his experience. The paper represents how Peter lives inauthentically because of having no desire to live according to the structures he adopts and how those structures of everyday life become repressive and

suffocating for him as they confine his identity within the heteronormative institutional life of the US during the long 1960s. Peter exemplifies the typical white, upper-middle class, suburban male of the day. Peter is confronted by Jerry, someone who lives authentically based on the tenets of the Beat Generation which advocate for self-fashioning as per one's preferences. Jerry lives freely and as per his will, even though it pushes him on the margins of the American society as a poor gay man. Jerry forces Peter to confront his passive state and unlived life by forcing him to remember the reality of the postmodern uncertainty. Both men in the play are very different from one another yet they both find themselves alienated individually and from the rest of society as well. Albee shows how the repressive conditions of the time, along with the general passivity of the American public in terms of fighting for change for a better and more inclusive society, created a crisis of masculinity for people. Albee illustrates how this crisis haunts people, regardless of whether they conform like Peter or live in irreverence like Jerry, that leads to terrible consequences in the form of violence, rage, alienation, social death and ultimately, even suicide.
Keywords: postmodernism, metanarrative, fictional pattern, forced forgetfulness, memory

Confronting Inauthentic Living in *The Zoo Story*

The Zoo Story is a play that is very minimalistic in its setting as it simply portrays two benches and two characters who, sitting on them, have a conversation. Its minimalism serves as a foil against the powerful ideological exposition that takes place through the interaction of the two characters. This ethos also supports Albee's purpose of wanting the audience to focus exclusively on the actual conversation that takes place. The title of the play, *The Zoo Story*, is meant to convey the boundaries that people impose upon themselves as they choose to live and function within a limited structure through a single metanarrative, which gives the illusion of inhabiting a singular and unquestionable reality. People's own fictional pattern becomes their "cage" through its singular and unquestionable status as it alienates people from parts of

themselves that cannot be incorporated on the basis of that fictional pattern. It also alienates them from other people who understand their lives through different fictional patterns. Therefore, a situation gets manufactured where people are isolated and suffering; living lives they do not like without any hope or prospect of change, they are like caged animals in a zoo. Hence, everyone is living "The Zoo Story."

The play represents Peter as a person who has structured his entire life on the basis of the grand narrative of the American Dream. His social status and class encourage him to perceive the narrative that results as absolutely true and real. During the long 1960s, the model of the nuclear family was a central and idealized component of the American Dream. As Stephanie Coontz points out in referencing the "glossy vision of the 1950s" (May 534), the nuclear family provided "the basis not only for social order but also for the American way of life, the essence of democracy, the foundation of the Free World during the Cold War" (May 534). Accordingly, Peter also manages to have a nuclear family that validates his belief that he is living the American Dream.

Initially, it seems that everything is going well for Peter—until he encounters Jerry and interacts with him in Central Park. However, as the conversation continues between the two men, it subtly begins to appear that Peter lives life without any existential satisfaction or passion. He just goes through the motions. Jerry leads his own bohemian life living in the tough and dire conditions of the Upper West Side of New York.[1] Living on the margins of American society as a poor gay man, Jerry has been able to see the fictionality of the "American Dream" by comprehending that it is primarily for straight, white and suburban males. Therefore, he refuses

1 The Upper West Side of New York is now one of the most expensive areas in the country but during the long 1960s, it provided affordable places to live for the poor.

2 A "beatnik" is someone influenced by the ideas of The Beat Generation, which started out as a literary movement. Through the works of Jack Kerouac and Allen Ginsberg, it grew into a cultural movement that characterised the counterculture of the long 1960s. The movement emphasized the importance of one's "self," advocating living authentically and freely through self-fashioning.

to configure his life according to the tenets of what he perceives as a fantasy. Rather, Jerry finds meaning for his life and desires through the art of self-fashioning, as advocated by the new counterculture of the long 1960s. He thus affirms his own perceptions and insists that he should live his life according to his preferences. Philip C. Kolin also argues that "Jerry is a part of the new generation of beatniks who frequented coffee houses, lived a bohemian lifestyle in Greenwich Village (as Albee himself did in the 1950s and 1960s)" (19).[2]

However, the confrontation that takes place between Peter and Jerry is about a lot more than the superficial differences between them. Jerry, for all the freedom that he has tried to assert in defining life through the influence of the Beat generation, has lived an existence of continuous suffering and extreme isolation, much like others on the Upper West Side of New York. His gay identity marginalises him as he fails to economically progress in any way as a result of the discrimination he faces. He makes a connection between his not having a heteronormative structure in the form of "one wife, two daughters" (Albee 8) and not living in "an apartment in the East Seventies" (Albee 8). He is routinely harassed because of being gay, which is why he tells Peter that he does not talk to people much except to tell them "'[k]eep your hands to yourself, buddy'" (Albee 5). It can be argued that this kind of violence caused "the Stonewall protests of gays and bisexuals"[3] (Kolin 17). Not only is Jerry poor, he lives in a "laughably small room" (Albee 8) where he suffers without anyone's support. Jerry's social condition is so terrible that it routinely thwarts or distorts his attempts to individually define his life through his chosen fictional pattern. Jerry staggers through life, watching movies he has already seen or that "are very much like one or several" (Albee 18) he has seen. He hopes to make his condition better by writing letters that plead for help, which are "'please' letters- 'Please why don't you do this?' and 'Please

3 Kolin argues that the Stonewall protests of gays and bisexuals became one of the many events that forced "the nation to confront its failings." The Stonewall protests were a series of protests which happened in reaction to a violent police raid conducted on June 28, 1969.

when will you do that?' letters. And when 'when' letters, too. 'When will you write?' 'When will you come? When?'" (Albee 9). The sheer quantity of these letters suggests that he has written many that have never been responded to by anyone who can help, including people in authority. This can explain his loss of faith in authority figures when, towards the end of the play, he says that "[y]ou won't find a policeman around here; they're all over on the west side of the park chasing fairies down from the trees or out of the bushes. That's all they do. That's their function" (Albee 25).

Jerry's ongoing experience of profound alienation makes him realise that his fictional pattern remains inadequate to deal with his social condition. He wishes to live freely to express his desires and form deep emotional attachments. However, society's homophobia and almost breathless avowal of the American Dream, which hides its bias against the poor and disenfranchised, prevent him from affirming those desires. He also realises that he is as alienated from others as they are from him. Jerry comprehends that this situation persists because his singular worldview aims to satisfy only his own "self" by thinking about things in his own preferred manner to create meaning in life for himself or as he declares to Peter, to "[m]ake sense out of things" (Albee 8), to "bring order" (Albee 8), "the old pigeon-hole bit" (Albee 8). The emphatic reliance on a single fictional pattern makes Jerry live in a limited manner, where he ceases to be able to develop different and alternate fictional patterns that could permit him to deal more effectively with his personal and social challenges. As with Jerry, these skills could create the freedom for him to live with greater imaginative multiplicity that would allow him a more nuanced identity and forms of expression. The use of a single fictional pattern also makes him evade or ignore people with different fictionalities in order to avoid conflicts because everyone's fiction is their unquestionable singular "reality," which does not allow them to accept other people's worldview. Jerry recognises that, in terms of living this way, he is not that different from

most people around him. He understands that in American society, due to the lack of reliable centres, people fearfully resort to "pigeon-hole" themselves within their own fictional patterns to live the illusion of complete meaning and certainty. Postmodern uncertainty scares them, that is, the uncertainty which is the result of the lack of definite or unquestionable status of most things in our reality. It is for this reason that, in spite of all the turbulence of the long 1960s, James T. Patterson states "[p]ublic opinion polls in the late 1950s and in 1960…reported that the American people were 'relaxed, unadventurous, comfortably satisfied with their way of life and blandly optimistic about the future'" (407). Jerry is aware of this "nonchalance" of the American public, where people avoid and ignore anything that does not directly concern the fictional pattern through which they understand their own personal lives.

Thus, when Jerry goes to the park, he has already had an epiphany, which informs his confronting Peter. It is for that reason that, before any dialogue is exchanged, Albee asserts that Jerry "has, to come closest to it, a great weariness" (Albee 1). Jerry carries the postmodern spirit with him in his belief that one must not cage oneself in their fiction, falsely believing it to be the sole reality. Instead he is convinced that it is important to be conscious of the fictionality of all fictions. Only then can one, without worry, comprehensively improve the "given" ways of their life by supplementing their inadequate fictional structures with new and different ideas that can make their lives better. Accepting the fictionality of all fictions would even help in understanding people with different fictional constructs than one's own. Hence, one can make improvements for oneself and others. As Hutcheon argues, postmodernism "acknowledges the human urge to make order, while pointing out that the orders we create are just that: human constructs, not natural or given entities" (*Poetics* 42). Hutcheon reasons that stripping away the "natural" or "given" status of existing structures becomes necessary to neutralize the hegemony of those

structures. Once that is achieved, room is made for different structures that could work better for people (43).

Peter is someone who seems to have the perfect life as he has everything he needs to sustain his fiction, like a well-paying job, elegant home, wife and two kids. Nevertheless, he has no existential satisfaction or passion for any of his accomplishments because his relationship to his fictional pattern and everything that it includes is one that lacks "authenticity." According to Thomas R. Flynn, "to be truly authentic is to have realized one's individuality" (74); furthermore, "[t]he person who avoids choice" (74), in terms of self-fashioning, "becomes a mere face in the crowd or cog in the bureaucratic machine, and has failed to become authentic" (74-75). This is Peter's problem; he has defined his life based on the "American Dream" in order to have the comfort of thinking he lives a "real" life. He has not been self-fashioning based on his own personal desires. Here, Albee shows how unquestionably accepting a single fictional pattern to define one's whole life can lead to inauthenticity and spiritual stagnation. Jerry recognises this inauthenticity in Peter very early in the play and, thus, knows that Peter's relationship to his fictional pattern must also be inauthentic. The encounter that leads to Jerry's recognition of this inauthenticity reveals this dynamic:

JERRY: Do you mind if we talk?

PETER (obviously minding) : Why - no, no.

JERRY: Yes, you do; you do…

PETER: No, really; I don't mind.

JERRY: Yes, you do. (Albee 3)

Albee shows how inauthentic behaviour is engendered because a wave of pragmatism has pervaded the US, where people cease to care about the "means" and only care about the "ends." Peter is solely invested in his goals of living an apparently happy and prosperous life. He does not seem to care about the means he uses to achieve those ends. That is why, in spite of having material comforts, he is so miserably uninvested and uninterested in the life he has laid out for himself. Through this portrayal, Albee shows why he prioritises living authentically over living pragmatically, even if it comes with some inconvenience.[4] After all, Peter may not have attained the material comforts he has if he did not live according to the metanarrative of the American Dream.

Jerry wants to make Peter realise the fictionality of his enactment of the American Dream and the existence of all other fictionalities to enable Peter to attain the freedom to choose fictions of his preference and also accept "different" perspectives of others. It is for this reason Jerry states: "A person has to have some way of dealing with *something*...With a bed, with a cockroach, with a mirror- no, that's too hard, that's one of the last steps…[w]ith an idea; a concept" (Albee 18-19). Jerry asserts that one's self should constantly be open to comprehend all types of fictions; they can then prioritise fictional patterns which suit their provisional preferences for self-fashioning rather than unquestionably accepting a fixed pattern that limits experience. Thus, the "mirror," which reflects one's self is "one of the last steps." At the same time, everyone's consciousness about the fictionality of their fiction would create an open-minded environment where people can "understand" (Albee 19) different people and "be understood" (Albee 19) by the same.

4 Albee's firm belief in living authentically in spite of the inconvenience that it may bring can be gleaned from his own personal life. Albee got thrown out of his wealthy adoptive parents' home because he was not the person they expected him to be. In his interview, Albee said "I think they wanted somebody who would be a corporate thug of some sort or perhaps a doctor or lawyer or something respectable. They didn't want a writer on their hands" (Rose 5:47-6:00). Albee did not mind being rejected for living authentically, even though "[f]or almost a decade afterwards" (Cohn 5), it led to "a hand-to-mouth existence in Greenwich Village" (Cohn 5).

Jerry makes Peter realise the fictionality of his investment in the American Dream and all of his other fictions by telling him his story about the dog. The latter is accomplished as Jerry's story with the dog is a fiction that contains many other people's fictions—including his own. Therefore, Peter's consciousness is forced to apprehend different fictional patterns from his chosen metanarrative of the American Dream. Lisa M. Siefker Bailey argues: "[o]ntologically, Jerry's world did not exist for Peter until Jerry told him about it. Jerry himself is not real to Peter until he makes himself known through the stories he tells" (40). Jerry talks about the lives that contradict the metanarrative of the American Dream. The "COLOURED QUEEN WHO WEARS A KIMONO AND PLUCKS HIS EYEBROWS" (Albee 19) and the "WOMAN WHO CRIES WITH DETERMINATION BEHIND HER CLOSED DOOR" (Albee 19), show that the US is more than a place of social ideals and perfect conditions—but rather a nation filled with people struggling to find themselves in an oppressive neoliberal culture. Peter is forced to accept fictions different from his own.

Peter's realisation of the fictionality of the American Dream also happens through Jerry's story with the dog. Jerry, through his story, metaphorically communicates how there are no actual emotional attachments between people anymore, even if there is the desire for attachments. There are just arrangements based on a common understanding where people stay away from each other as they cannot accept each other's differences. Like Jerry and the dog at the end of the story, who "have attained a compromise" (Albee 20), they "neither love nor hurt because" (Albee 20) they "do not try to reach each other" (Albee 20). The story ends, with Peter remaining "silent" (Albee 20) and "disturbed" (Albee 20). Peter feels disturbed because he is alerted to the fantasy of the American Dream through this story of "arrangements without attachments." This happens because not only does this Dream promise that anyone in the US can obtain success and upward mobility through hard work, supposedly guaranteeing happiness and fulfilment, but it also

promises that one can provide the same to their family as a consequence. As earlier stated in this chapter, family was very much a part of the "American Dream." Therefore, Peter learns the insidiousness of his fiction because he realises that this "given" of the American Dream is absent from his life. Not only is he unable to confer happiness and fulfilment to his family but he lacks even the vaguest sense of emotional attachment to them.

Peter's inauthentic relationship to his aspirations alienates him so much from himself and others that, rather than forming emotional attachments with his wife and kids, he tries to get time and space solely for himself in "Central Park, New York, on a Sunday afternoon in summer" (Albee 1). Later, he even tells Jerry that he sits on the bench there "almost every Sunday afternoon" (Albee 24), days he could spend with his family but he does not because "[i]t's secluded" (Albee 24) and he can be alone. Albee symbolically even conveys the lack of attachments in Peter's homelife when Jerry tickles him and he blurts out "[h]ee, hee, hee. After all…Stop, stop. Hee, hee, hee. After all the parakeets will be getting dinner ready soon. Hee, hee. And the cats are setting the table" (Albee 22). The most basic dynamics of his homelife get muddled up by him because he has not developed strong emotional connections or attachments with anyone in the family. The family merely exists, for him, to be the manifestations of his narcissistic fantasies.

After realising the inauthenticity of his life, Peter does not experience the psychological insight or embrace the freedom that Jerry expects him to, like Jerry himself has. On the contrary, Peter "almost tearfully" (Albee 20) asks him "[w]hy did you tell me all of this?" (Albee 20). This signifies that Peter was someone who was aware of the postmodern condition. Yet he deliberately chose to live the illusion of inhabiting a singular and complete reality through the metanarrative of the American Dream. Jerry "furiously" (Albee 20) accuses Peter of being in denial about the psychological revelations he has through Jerry's story with the dog. Peter's response is denial, as

he shouts "*I don't understand!*" (Albee 20) and "*I don't want to hear anymore*. I don't understand you, or your landlady, or her dog…" (Albee 21).

Jerry gets angry and disillusioned through seeing Peter like this because it signifies that the latter is so fearful of living authentically that he would rather pursue an illusion, even if it means living an unfulfilled, isolated and a spiritually stagnant life. Peter even rationalizes his decision by proclaiming that, "People can't have everything they want. You should know that; it's a rule; people can have some of the things they want, but they can't have everything" (Albee 24).

In his interview, Albee emphasized the need to "not die before you're dead" (Rose 10:04-10:07). Here, Albee refers to a "social death" that one suffers when they are not living authentically. Jerry recognizes that Peter has suffered this social death as Peter is in denial of the metanarrative of God, even though his desire for emotional attachment continues to exist because of its influence since the need for fellow-feeling is an integral part of the Christian tradition. Thus, Jerry challenges Peter's denial of God in several instances. When Peter says "Oh, my; oh, my!" (Albee 10) without saying "God," Jerry immediately challenges his denial by saying "Oh, your what?" (Albee 10). Peter, in rejecting the idea of a deity, instead, seeks assurance and stability by immersing himself in the metanarrative of the American Dream. Ironically, this concept perhaps only reinforced his desires for emotional attachment provided by the metanarrative of God. This happens because the metanarrative of the American Dream, in its assertion of how happiness and fulfilment can be conferred upon the family through conformity to social conventions, considers the idea of emotional attachments with one's own family itself as "given." In the end, Peter suffers a crisis because that which is "given" for him—whether related to the expectations of Christianity or the American Dream— is absent in his life.

Jerry, in the spirit of a postmodernist, realises that "fact is better left to fiction" (Albee 13), that the "facts" about our reality are only known through the "fictions" we construct which provide meanings, even if they are limited. It is for this reason that while Jerry informs Peter of the fictionality of the "American Dream" and takes its "grand" status away from him, he also asserts the importance of the metanarrative of God, in spite of its obvious limits, by saying "Oh, what is the word I want to put justice to your…*Jesus*" (Albee 25). What Jerry means by referencing "God" is that Christianity, through its emphasis on fellow-feeling, provides some meaning to deal with a plethora of problems. Through this, Albee demonstrates the futility of a total rejection or acceptance of a metanarrative or any fictional pattern. He advocates for a confluence of the two, which is to say, he only wants the fictionality of fictions to be acknowledged. Thus, individuals can conveniently follow their desires by using any fictional pattern where it is needed and discarding those which are not.

However, Peter is in complete denial: he would rather live the illusion of having the absolute certainty and self-assurance permitted by a single fictional pattern, even if it means living inauthentically and isolated from others. He is too fearful to live honestly with any form of uncertainty. The reason this angers and further accentuates Jerry's despair is that it confirms to Jerry that Peter would continue living the same way, like others, without doing anything to improve social conditions for himself and others. He would rather live with the illusion of the American Dream and ignore anything that does not reinforce his narcissistic ideals, the delusions through which he understands his own life. Jerry, already having suffered and struggled a lot, loses all hope and decides to kill himself because of the danger of this purposeful passivity. Jerry is disillusioned because while he may live his life authentically, his very identity as a gay man is a criminal offense during the time. He cannot express his desires openly in an attempt to form

any attachments without running the risk of being ostracized or incarcerated. Mary Jo Bona points out that,

> "In the United States after 1950, Joseph McCarthy's House Un-American Activities Committee…classified homosexuals along with communists as dangerous, claiming that they were at risk of blackmail and therefore potential subversives who should be ostracized from government or made subject to punishment through incarceration" (210).

The institutional homophobia further fuelled cultural homophobia. Jerry's deranged state is a direct consequence of constantly living under suspicion of possible state repression, which creates an anxiety-ridden experience for him. Therefore, encountering Peter's purposeful passivity disillusions Jerry even more because it tells him that people like Peter, who represent the status quo, will never fight for any social change for marginalised people like him. The event that makes Jerry lose any hope of possible redemption from his terrible condition is one where he identifies Peter as a latent gay man himself. It is important to note that not only is Peter spending a Sunday away from his family but he also chooses to be in Central Park, which "has been for more than a century a site generally conducive to encounters between male strangers that could, and regularly did, result in sexual liaisons" (Leasure 36-37). While Peter is not necessarily knowingly seeking such an encounter, he is perhaps unconsciously there as a result of his suppressed curiosity and desire. On top of that, for all his adherence to conventions, he does not try to distance himself from Jerry even after discovering his gay identity. He only grows more curious about him as the play goes on. Finally, when Jerry tickles him to make him stay on the bench, Peter goes in a "mad whimsy" (Albee 22) as he panics from the pleasure of the contact that is made and laughs uncontrollably. Throughout the episode, Peter continues to suggest that he has to go home. Apprehending Peter's homophobic panic and his desire to still go back to the life he has laid out for himself symbolically tells Jerry how entrenched neoliberal heteronormativity is within

American culture. He sees how quickly the slightest presence of homoerotic desire will be crushed after it is observed. Hence, Jerry throws Peter's unlived life in his face by calling him a "vegetable" (Albee 28) and forces an altercation to commit assisted suicide as he sees redemption for himself only in death. Therefore, he finds peace in death, as "[h]is features relax, and while his voice varies, sometimes wrenched with pain, for the most part he seems removed from his dying" (Albee 28).

Peter, having his "social death" thrown in his face, overcompensates for that in anger by following his instinct for the first time by engaging in the altercation with Jerry. What happens to Peter after Jerry's death remains uncertain. Jerry does make him aware, for a moment, of his inauthentic life and the social death he has suffered in order to live with complete certainty. Nevertheless, whether or not Peter will accept that and do something about it remains ambiguous as the play ends when he flees the scene.

Albee highlights how a crisis of masculinity ensued in the US during the long 1960s because the nation failed to offer any space for the expression of machismo. Clare Virginia Eby points out that "[t]he bureaucratization of America and the growth in service-sector jobs minimized opportunities to display the aggressive and entrepreneurial acts by which an earlier generation had defined masculinity" (602). Albee shows how this led to a situation where people had to make a choice. They either, like Peter, could surrender their own free will to live the American Dream by being a part of the institutional culture of the US or they could protect their free will but at the cost of being pushed to the margins of the society to lead impoverished and disenfranchised lives, like Jerry. In both cases, emasculation became a perpetual part of people's lives as they could not express themselves authentically.

Albee shows how the absence of any legitimate structures to express masculinity creates not only a heightened need in people to express their machismo but it also leads them to express it in extreme ways with their anger and frustration. Albee illustrates this through the portrayal of his characters engaging in different forms of violence. Jerry has fantasies of unnecessary and cruel violence for no apparent reason. At the beginning of the play, he suggests to Peter how it is "too bad" (Albee 6) that his daughters' parakeets do not carry any disease. He states that "[i]f they did you could set them loose in the house and the cats could eat them and die, maybe" (Albee 6). His story with the dog (whether it actually happened or not) involves him taking the extreme measure to poison the dog, which suggests a penchant for violence. The verbal violence that both Peter and Jerry inflict on one another towards the play's climax is a means for both of them to reassert their masculinity by emasculating the other. Peter calls Jerry a "bum" (Albee 25) and Jerry calls him a "vegetable" (Albee 25). Ultimately, this verbal violence leads to physical violence as they both fight each other. Jerry remains quite unaffected by Peter's verbal attacks because he knows that, while he may have led an emasculated life, it was due more to social limitation than anything else. Peter, on the other hand, is responsible for his own state. Hence, Peter initiates the physical altercation as he overcompensates for the emasculation he feels when Jerry throws the idea of his social death in his face. Of course, Jerry uses the altercation to kill himself, which is a consequence of his disillusionment. However, his doing so also leads to him taking complete control of the situation and his fate at the same time. Thus, his suicide also becomes a means for him to reassert his masculinity.

Albee explores forced forgetfulness as a particular process of memory that Peter uses to forget about postmodern uncertainty and the metanarrative of God. Peter is someone who only wishes to operate in life with absolute certainty and since the existence of God has been largely undermined in the twentieth century, the notion of using Christianity to live with certainty ceases

to appeal him. Hence, the American Dream, which was largely uncontested during the long 1960s, attracts him. However, Peter's need to forget the narrative of Christianity does show that he did have a desire to live according to its strictures because if it did not matter to him, he would not need to repress its presence for himself in the first place. Forced forgetfulness is a two-step process where first, denial and ignorance have to take the place of that which one wants to forget. Then, new fictional patterns have to be accepted in order to discard the information that individuals are trying to forcibly forget. Forced Forgetfulness can take place like this, as according to Jonathan K. Foster, "memory fades or decays away" (62) over time. He also argues that memory can also be "disrupted, obscured or overlaid by other memories" (62), which can be accomplished through imbibing new fictional patterns within one's consciousness. This is exactly what Peter does. After losing faith in the metanarrative of God and falling into existential uncertainty, he forcibly forgets both through denial and ignorance because he fears living in acceptance of the postmodern condition and its resulting uncertainty. Instead, he uses the metanarrative of the American Dream to live life with absolute certainty and assurance, which also helps further in forcibly forgetting as the fictional patterns within it "disrupt," "obscure" and "overlay" everything that he was forcibly forgetting in the first place.

Quite early in the play, Albee illustrates how the process of forced forgetfulness takes place. Jerry tells Peter how he uses a self-constructed fiction to keep his sexually-harassing landlady away from him. He states,

> "I merely say: 'But, love; wasn't yesterday enough for you, and the day before?' Then she puzzles, she makes slits of her tiny eyes, she sways a little, and then…a simple-minded smile begins to form on her awful face, and she giggles and groans as she thinks about yesterday and the day before; as she believes and relives what never happened." (Albee 13)

Here, Albee shows how the landlady forcibly forgets her memories of the last two days by denying and ignoring what she remembered of those two days. Then, she uses Jerry's fiction about their sexual engagements to replace those memories. As stated above, Peter uses this same strategy to forcibly forget his spiritual void in order to live with complete certainty through the reassurance of the American Dream, which in turn furthers the process of forcibly forgetting.

It can be seen through the text that Peter relieved himself of his postmodern anxiety and apprehension through adhering to social convention, seeming to convey an absolute certainty about the life he leads. Thus, when Jerry exclaims, "[y]ou're married!" (Albee 3), Peter responds by saying "(*with pleased emphasis*) [w]hy, certainly" (Albee 3). He assumes that one has to be married, so he is. Only towards the end, when the metanarrative of the American Dream fragments for him and he becomes overwhelmed by a sense of uncertainty does he recall his previous forms of forcibly forgetting. Therefore, when Jerry impales himself on the knife, Peter exclaims "Oh, my God!" (Albee 29), instead of just "oh, my" as earlier. Also, as stated in the previously, Peter asks Jerry not "what" but "why did you tell me all of this?" (Albee 17), which shows that he did have an awareness of his postmodern uncertainty from encountering it before.[5] Hence, he asks this question because he is upset about retrieving the knowledge of postmodern uncertainty again. Peter is unable to accept the idea of living with postmodern uncertainty and that he wasted a lot of his time living the illusion of absolute certainty. For this reason, Roudané states of Albee's plays: "[t]he tragic irony, of course, lies in the fact that too often his characters become aware – after it is 'all over'" (*Critical Introduction* 10). Therefore, Peter subsequently tries the same two-step strategy of forcibly forgetting again. He resorts to "negation" (Freud 275) by overemphasising that he does not "understand" (Albee 21) anything and states "*I don't want*

5 Though Peter's memory, of encountering the fictional nature of reality before, only gets retrieved through his apprehension of the postmodern condition again through Jerry's story about the dog. The story illustrates, as stated in the previous chapter on the play, not to consider one's own fictional pattern or worldview to be the sole reality.

to hear anymore" (Albee 21), so that he can once again be in denial and pretend ignorance of what he realised.

It is important to understand why and how Peter is able to retrieve his memory of forcibly forgetting by simply gaining awareness of how much of reality is a product of fictional constructions and thereby always non-definite. Foster argues that "memory involves not just taking in and storing information, but the ability to retrieve it too. And all three components have to work well together if our memory is to work efficiently" (25). Peter loses the ability to retrieve the information about postmodern uncertainty and the metanarrative of God through the process of forced forgetfulness. He does not lose the information, which he encoded, from the storage of memory altogether because there is fluid movement between different meaning systems and the difference between them allows meaning to emerge for each one of them. Therefore, Peter unintentionally retrieves the knowledge of everything that he forcibly forgot when he encounters Jerry. In effect Peter responds as he does because "[w]hat we are able to retrieve depends largely on the context in which the information was encoded or classified in the first place, and to what extent this matches the retrieval context – this is the so-called *encoding specificity principle*" (Foster 50). In other words, towards the end when Peter again feels uncertain, the similarity of that experience with the time when he previously felt like that brings back his memories of how he tried to forcefully forget the narrative of Christianity after losing faith in it and the resulting uncertainty in terms of living life with complete assurance.

Thereafter, Peter attempts to forcibly forget again. He responds in denial to the memories he retrieves and the "different" lives of other people (that Jerry tells him about) in order to deny the realisation they bring about in regard to the fictionality of the American Dream and reality itself. Peter once again tries to re-establish, for himself, the unquestionable and singular status of the metanarrative of the American Dream by using its fictional patterns. At first, Jerry assumes

that Peter wants to live in ignorance of the fictional nature of reality and the lives of other, often marginalised people.[6] For this reason, Jerry rhetorically asks Peter, "I suppose you don't quite know what to make of me, eh?" (Albee 21). Nevertheless, to Jerry's surprise, Peter responds by saying "[w]e get all kinds in publishing. (*He chuckles*)" (Albee 21). Peter, through his statement, asserts that he does understand that Jerry is gay because of his experience in the business of publishing.[7] Jerry grasps that while Peter does not wish to know about the lives of people like him, he is aware of Jerry's gay identity and has some excitement about it. It is important to note that right after Peter asserts that he knows Jerry is gay, he "chuckles" about it excitedly. Thus, Jerry comprehends that the reason Peter wishes to immerse himself only within the narrative of the American Dream and its heteronormative conventions is because he cannot come to terms with his own repressed homosexuality. Jerry realises that Peter's adherence to heteronormative and conventional ways of life are all about him trying to fit in and be accepted by the majority of the society that upholds the status quo. After all, the play is set during the late 1950s, an era notorious for its conformity. Therefore, Richard M. Fried argues that "[t]he 1950s gave voice to many critiques of American society…Americans were frequently chided as timid conformists, non-rockers of the boat, privatists, and members of a 'silent generation'" (75).

Jerry tries to make Peter come to terms with the latter's latent homoerotic feelings. Jerry hopes that if he can help Peter come to terms with his desires, then maybe Peter could be satisfied enough to care about other people. That is why Jerry asks him, "Peter, do I annoy you, or confuse you?" (Albee 21). Jerry hopes that Peter can accept his confusion, which would allow him to accept his homoerotic impulses. Jerry makes a sexual advance towards Peter by telling him, "I'm

6 Accepting the fictionality of reality would extinguish Peter's sense of total assurance about his life. And, differences of other people, including Jerry's sexuality, simply cannot be perceived or accepted.

7 Here, Peter is not only referring to the advent of Gay Pulp Fiction in the 1950s, paperbacks of which were published by major publishers. He is also alluding to the rise of gay writers who dealt with the subject of homosexuality, like James Baldwin, Allen Ginsberg and Tennessee Williams. This could also include the many queer people who worked behind the scenes in the arts and culture industries.

here, and I'm not leaving" (Albee 21). However, Peter attempts to ignore his sexual advance by trying to leave. Then, Jerry makes another sexual advance by tickling him. Peter feels a sense of pleasure and then feels ashamed because of it. Hence, he reacts in homophobic panic by hysterically laughing. Throughout his panic episode, Peter continues to express his desire to go home, back to his stagnant life. Jerry gets extremely emotionally aggressive to see Peter not recognise his own homoerotic desires because it tells him that Peter would never fight for any change for people like him as Peter cannot even fight for himself or his own desires. Peter understandably fears the idea of being an anomaly or a part of some minority group so much that he does not want to accept his homosexual desires. He even remains in denial of his homophobic panic by claiming he does not know "what happened" (Albee 22) to him. After all, Jerry's own state must have demonstrated to Peter the suffering he could endure as a consequence of accepting his latent sexuality. Hence, Jerry gets completely disillusioned and decides to kill himself through assisted suicide by using Peter.

Albee shows that the consequences of denial and repression are devastating. He suggests that existential problems must be dealt with, forgetting them will only exacerbate them. Peter fears the uncertain consequences of acting upon his homosexual impulses so much that he goes into denial about the fictional or constructed status of reality and the freedom offered if he acknowledged its complexity. Instead he chooses to live the illusion of a "real" and certain life. Hence, Peter attempts to reduce his identity to a single and a fixed self by defining his entire life through the embrace of heteronormative conventions. But his homoerotic and emotional desires to connect with another man remain repressed because he cannot in any way rebel against the dominant conventions. The only thing he does "for years" (Albee 27) of his own accord is escape his own heterosexual, upper-middle class existence by going to a bench every Sunday. The bench in Central Park provides some much needed consolation to Peter in the form of isolation and

inaction. It allows him to withdraw from the conventional life that he has no passion towards. Consequently, not only does Peter get alienated, he stays alienated. Peter gets through his life simply being convinced of its "reality" and taking "satisfaction" (Albee 27) in a life of accomplishment and emotional passivity symbolised by his time on the bench.

Albee shows how Peter's suppression of his desires leads to an eruption in extreme behaviour when Jerry takes his bench and the sense of certainty that Peter is trying to reinforce after being in denial of everything he learns through Jerry's stories. Jerry aggressively throws Peter's social death in his face by suggesting how he has never been able to act authentically. Jerry does this by calling him a "vegetable" (Albee 24) and telling him that their confrontation registers "probably the first time" (Albee 24) that Peter has had "anything more trying to face than changing" (Albee 26) his "cats' toilet box" (Albee 26). This destroys Peter's attempts to tell himself that he lives the perfect life. Peter gets angry as a consequence because of his realisation that his life is, in a way, unlived; this exchange, in turn, makes him feel inadequate and insignificant. According to Carl Jung, we strive unconsciously for significance and adequacy that we consciously lack (63). Peter unconsciously overcompensates for his feelings of insufficiency and inadequacy by getting in a physical altercation with Jerry that ends with Jerry's death. While Peter does not intend to kill Jerry, he does engage in the struggle for a bench and picks up a knife in anger during that altercation. The deconstructed nature of Peter's self emerges in an extreme form. While he does become more than someone who just lives the "American Dream," this someone happens to be a very violent and hyperaggressive individual.

According to Karl Marx, those who are alienated from themselves are, by extension, also alienated from others around them (165-166, 170). Peter's internalised alienation also makes him alienated from other people. As previously mentioned, he has no connection with his wife and kids; in addition, Peter is completely alienated from other people who inhabit New York City.

Peter, having been alienated and burdened by his own life, only uses his free time to take pleasure in the withdrawal from his own life. Inactivity is what he requires after being unwillingly involved in the activities that maintain his privileged lifestyle. He is left with no mental space, time or energy to invest his interest in the lives of other inhabitants in the city, including the poor and disenfranchised. Therefore, when Jerry tells him about the cramped spaces that people share in a single building where he lives, Peter is completely taken aback by it. Hence, he asks Jerry a question that only someone without awareness would pose: "why do you live there?" (Albee 8). Anyone aware of their social surroundings would never ask why poor and marginalised people live in such dire conditions. Peter is so estranged from the social life around him that he finds it "unthinkable" (Albee 13) that some people on the Upper West Side, living in desperate conditions, could act in an unstable manner.

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